

Introduction to Human Communication: COMM 108
Lecture Notes OUTLINE: Ch. 3 Culture & Communication

I. Culture

A. DEF.

- a. Traditions, customs, norms, beliefs, values, thought patterns, that are passed down from generation to generation

B. Versus Race & Ethnicity

“Sub” versus “Co”

a. Subculture

- i. Drawn from an overarching culture
- ii. Subculture take parts from other cultures

b. Co-Culture

- i. Implies same status in culture
- ii. A hierarchy of cultures within the overarching culture

C. Characteristics of Culture

1. Culture is learned:

- i. Culture a nature vs. nurture debate
 - 1. In academics culture is decided to be entirely based on nurture
- ii. Culture is completely learned (nurture)
- iii. As humans we are all born as a “blank slate”
 - 1. We learn culture through our interactions

2. Cultures are:

- i. Cultures are a group’s understanding of itself
- ii. Culture is a collective not an individual’s understanding of it
 - 1. One person doesn’t represent a culture
 - 2. Ex: If someone is a murderer we can all agree that is wrong
- iii. If you don’t care about the consequences, you can do whatever you want
 - 1. By breaking the norm, you are essentially ostracizing yourself from that culture
- iv. Most of us need culture because it provides us with food, shelter, safety, etc.

3. Cultures are multifaceted:

a. Cultures are made of many parts

- i. Language, religion, and laws
 - 1. You must be aware of the religious makeup of the culture, but it is not necessary to participate in religion

- 2. Similarly with laws, it is only necessary to be familiar with them
- ii. Without understanding the core parts of the culture parts you are blind to it

4. Cultures are dynamic:

- i. Culture is always changing
 - 1. Rate of cultural change is pathetic
- ii. Catalysts of cultural change:
 - 1. Technology
 - a. Ex: The invention of the smartphone
 - 2. Natural disaster
 - a. Ex: Tsunami
 - 3. War
 - a. Ex: The War on Terror

5. Cultural identities are overlapping:

- i. All of us are members of many cultures
 - 1. Some we hold dear others we do not
- ii. Most of the cultures we subscribe to have overlap
- iii. You combine the cultures you take part in to create your Self-Identity

II. Ethnocentrism

A. Think of Ethnocentrism as a neutral term:

- i. It is like a fire; it can be dangerous but can also be helpful

A. Defined:

- a. Ethnocentrism is the tendency to view one's cultural affiliation as central, normal, & good while viewing others as less normal

B. Positive Ethnocentrism

- a. Survival – to continue to exist
 - i. Ethnocentrism keeps a culture alive
 - ii. Without taking pride in culture and maintaining its rituals it will slowly disappear
- b. Cohesion – solidarity
 - i. Ethnocentrism keeps the members of a culture together in a sort of tribe
- c. All cultures are Ethnocentric
 - i. The issue is how Ethnocentric you are
- d. Positive Ethnocentrism culminates in the maintenance of a culture

C. Potential problems resulting from Ethnocentrism

- 1. Culture shock:

- **Culture Shock is the trauma experienced by entering a new culture**
 - **Ex: Being on a business trip but you cannot sleep no matter what**
- **With low ethnocentrism you only see that there is a difference instead of being psychologically paralyzed by said difference**

2. Stereotyping:

- **DEF: When a group of people from a culture are perceived to share one or several characteristics**

3. Prejudice:

- **DEF: Biased judgements made towards others in advance to knowing them**
 - **This judgement is severely limited and highly inaccurate**

C. The ethnocentrism continuum

- These are the grouping of people based on their level of ethnocentrism**
- The following list goes from least to highest level of ethnocentrism**

1. Equality:

- **Lowest level of ethnocentrism**
- **Someone who looks to communicate with all humans with little to no concern about the others culture**
- **They acknowledge cultural differences as nothing but a difference**
- **They do not shy away from sensitive topics based on their audience**

2. Sensitivity:

- **Moderately low levels of ethnocentrism**
- **Open to speaking with people of all cultures but will avoid sensitive topics**

3. Indifference:

- **Moderate levels of ethnocentrism**
- **Neutral, they do not care about other cultures**
 - **Not in favor of not against another culture**
- **Won't run towards or away from other cultures**
- **"comfortable" within their own cultural affiliations**
 - **They understand the issues and flaws of their own culture but are comfortable within it**
 - **They prefer to talk to other members of their culture**

- If given the choice they will stay within their own culture
- They feel as if there will always be a disconnect between their own and other people's culture

4. Avoidance:

- Moderately high levels of ethnocentrism
- “Our ways are right, their ways are wrong”
- They believe they know their culture, what it's about, its rituals, etc.
 - They believe they know who a member is (most of the time)
- They only want to talk to members
 - They avoid people of other cultures
- These people do not hate other cultures but simply prefer to avoid them if possible
 - Their communication with other cultures can be pleasant or lead to conflict
- Ex:
 - The Amish
 - They avoid other cultures
 - But they are not looking for conflict

5. Disparagement:

- Extremely high levels of ethnocentrism
- These people are extremists
- These people make up hate groups
 - Bigots, racists, sexists, etc.
- Usually, they don't come at you directly
 - You will feel hostility when you are in a room with them
- Operate with extreme prejudice with people of other cultures
- “If you don't feel the same way as me about culture you are wrong”
- They like to make a lot of noise
 - This group generally does not grow
 - They tend to get louder during times of discourse
 - EX: Racists stirring up trouble during the trump administration

III. Cultural Dimensions (Hall)

A. High/Low Context Cultures

1. General Description:

- The context tells you where to look for a meaning in a message

- Which words are key words
- What non-verbals to look for
- What are they wearing

2. Low Context Cultures:

- Explicitly coded
- Communication is focused on verbals
 - Non-verbals are still important, but not the focus
- ~40% of meaning is found in verbals
- Low context cultures are very direct
 - Much of the meaning comes through the words
- Yes, means yes, no means no
- U.S. is a low context culture
 - Other examples: Swiss & Germans

3. High Context Cultures:

- Implicit/indirect
 - Communication is ambiguous
- If you are an outsider, the meaning feels covert
 - There are many subtleties to communication you will not understand as an outsider
- Examples of high context situations:
 - Talking with family, friends, or partners
 - They can tell what you are saying with your looks
 - No one else fully understands what you mean
- Everyone is in on those signals within a high context culture
- In a high context culture, the receiver has a greater burden to understand the meaning
- High context cultures are other face oriented, it is up to you to build up the other person's image
- Ex:
 - Japan

B. Time Orientations of Cultures

- Is time a real thing, some cultures say yes, some say no
- All cultures will tell you what you should do with your time

1. Polychronic (P-time) Cultures

Perspective on time:

- Polychronic cultures believe time is “not real”

Descriptions & Attributes:

- Polychronic culture has a lower value of time
- They are people centered/ relationally oriented
- You take on multiple tasks at a time
- Think of Polychronic cultures as a “large meeting room”
 - It is not impossible to be late
- In a Polychronic culture you should be working on every relationship you come across
 - Priority is given to a relationship
- Almost offensive to say “I’d like to chat but I’m late...”

Leadership (needs):

- Gifted leadership
- Leader needs to be a talented cognitive multitasker
 - It is a person who is in that large room training people to work, talking with the accounting department, wooing a client, and getting a new client all at the same time while being fully engaged in every conversation

Challenges:

- In a Polychronic culture there is a large feeling of unity
 - When you go to a monochronic culture you will feel isolated
- Very inward oriented
 - You need to know someone to get something done
- Polychronic cultures have difficulty dealing with new things
- Examples of Polychronic cultures:
 - The Mediterranean, Southern Europe, and parts of south-central Asia

2. Monochronic (M-time) Cultures

Perspective on time:

- A Monochronic culture believes that time is “real”
- They value time structures
 - Schedule one task at one time

Descriptions & Attributes:

- The language reflects the culture
 - “Time is money”
 - “We are working against the clock”
- Everything must show up in schedules
 - Take on one task at a time
- Priority is placed on tasks not on relationships
- If you have a relational issue: “Figure it out”
- A Monochronic culture is like a “smaller office”
 - only those scheduled allowed in

- Door is shut
- Intensify nature of relationship within that room
- Private issues are discussed privately
- A monochronic culture is good at dealing with issues that are new and difficult
 - A monochronic culture is efficient

Leadership (needs):

- Semi-confident leadership
 - Leadership does not have to be very competent
 - A monochronic culture knows how to get things done with an incompetent leader

Challenges:

- A monochronic culture is blind to the humanity of its members
- Higher levels of loneliness are experienced within a monochronic culture
 - Its members feel more alienated
- Examples of monochronic culture:
 - The U.S., the Swiss, the Germans, Japanese